

Primary Source Reading 1: The Problem of Evil, Stated

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From David Hume's Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion, Parts 10–11 (1779) — text unaltered

Before you read: Demea and Philo, usually opposed to one another, find themselves in complete agreement on one point: that human life is full of suffering. What begins as a shared observation about misery becomes, in Philo's hands, the sharpest challenge to Cleanthes' entire argument for a good and powerful God. Watch how the catalogue of suffering builds toward the question Philo borrows from the ancient philosopher Epicurus — a question natural theology has never fully answered.

The Testimony of Human Misery

DEMEA: The people, indeed, are sufficiently convinced of this great and melancholy truth. The miseries of life; the unhappiness of man; the general corruptions of our nature; the unsatisfactory enjoyment of pleasures, riches, honours; these phrases have become almost proverbial in all languages. And who can doubt of what all men declare from their own immediate feeling and experience?

And why should man pretend to an exemption from the lot of all other animals? The whole earth, believe me, Philo, is cursed and polluted. A perpetual war is kindled amongst all living creatures. Necessity, hunger, want, stimulate the strong and courageous: Fear, anxiety, terror, agitate the weak and infirm. The first entrance into life gives anguish to the new-born infant and to its wretched parent: Weakness, impotence, distress, attend each stage of that life: and it is at last finished in agony and horror. (*Part 10*)

The Cruelty Built Into Nature

PHILO: Observe too, the curious artifices of Nature, in order to embitter the life of every living being. The stronger prey upon the weaker, and keep them in perpetual terror and anxiety. The weaker too, in their turn, often prey upon the stronger, and vex and molest them without relaxation. Consider that innumerable race of insects, which either are bred on the body of each animal, or, flying about, infix their stings in him. These insects have others still less than themselves, which torment them. And thus on each hand, before and behind, above and below, every animal is surrounded with enemies, which incessantly seek his misery and destruction. (*Part 10*)

[Demea and Philo continue in this vein for some time, cataloguing the miseries of disease, poverty, oppression, and the universal fear of death. Cleanthes objects that they are painting an exaggerated, one-sided picture. Philo turns directly to him.]

Epicurus's Old Questions

PHILO: And is it possible, Cleanthes, that after all these reflections, and infinitely more, which might be suggested, you can still persevere in your Anthropomorphism, and assert the moral attributes of the Deity, his justice, benevolence, mercy, and rectitude, to be of the same nature with these virtues in human creatures? His power we allow is infinite: whatever he wills is executed: but neither man nor any other animal is happy: therefore he does not will their happiness. His wisdom is infinite: He is never mistaken in choosing the means to any end: But the course of Nature tends not to human or animal felicity: therefore it is not established for that purpose. Through the whole compass of human knowledge, there are no inferences more certain and infallible than these. In what respect, then, do his benevolence and mercy resemble the benevolence and mercy of men?

Epicurus's old questions are yet unanswered. Is he willing to prevent evil, but not able? then is he impotent. Is he able, but not willing? then is he malevolent. Is he both able and willing? whence then is evil? (*Part 11*)

After you read: Philo's question is not new — he explicitly borrows it from Epicurus, writing more than two thousand years earlier. That is part of the point: this is not a modern objection invented by skeptics unfamiliar with religious tradition. It is among the oldest and most persistent challenges natural theology has faced. As you move into the next reading, notice that the responses to this challenge are, in their own way, just as old — they were being worked out by Christian thinkers centuries before Hume ever wrote a word.